



**MLS NEXT ALLSTATE HOMEGROWN DIVISION
TECHNICAL STANDARDS
2026–2027**

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I. GENERAL

a. Age Groups

MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Age Groups for the 2026-2027 Season are as follows, U13, U14, U15, U16, U17, and U19.

Playoff Age Groups are as follows, U15, U16, U17, and U19, with U13 and U14 participating in a Quality of Play Playoff structure.

b. High School Soccer Participation

High school soccer participation is not permitted by Players in the MLS NEXT Homegrown Division, with limited exceptions. High school soccer participation is outlined further in Section VII(c) of the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Rules & Regulations.

c. College Player Participation

Players who have participated or are participating in any college program at any level (i.e. NCAA Division I, junior college) are not permitted to participate in MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division.

d. Professional Player Participation

An MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division age-eligible Player who competes with an MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Club's professional team, is permitted to participate in MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division so long as this player meets all MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division registration requirements and participates with the Club that is registered in MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division regardless of that player's contractual status.

e. Outside Competition

i. Event Participation

MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Team may only participate in approved outside tournaments, showcases, or events.

Requests can be made by completing the [Outside Competition Form](#). MLS NEXT Staff will evaluate each request according to their consistency with these Technical Standards, schedule, and commercial conflicts.

ii. League Participation

Primary Players are not permitted to participate in outside leagues.

iii. Talent Identification

Primary Players may only participate in approved outside talent identification events with U.S. Soccer, Canadian Soccer, and all other FIFA recognized international federations. Players can participate in any National Team call-up at any time.

II. ROSTERS

a. Minimums & Maximums

The minimum number of players on an MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division roster is 14 players per Team.

The maximum number of players on an MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division roster is 28 players per Team.

b. Matchday

The maximum number of players on an MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division matchday roster for regular season matches is 18 players per team.

The maximum number of players on an MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division matchday roster for Events is 20 players per team.

c. Overage Players

A maximum of three (3) overage players (i.e. birth year of 2007) on the U19 roster are permitted. These players cannot be registered as Late Developers.

d. Start Percentage

It is recommended, for all age groups, that all Primary Players start in 25% of official matches. For the U13 age group, it is required that each player on the matchday roster must play at least one (1) period uninterrupted. For the U14 and U15 age groups, it is recommended that all players participate in 50% of minutes per week.

e. Playing Up

Players are eligible to play in an older age group while being rostered in their younger birth year age group, so long as they meet competition standards and play only 90 minutes per day across a maximum of two (2) matches.

f. Player Designations

i. Primary (P) Player

Primary Players are top players at each Club are expected to only be registered within the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division. Primary Players are not permitted to play with another team within the Club at any level outside of the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown

Division. Clubs must have a minimum of fourteen (14) registered Primary Players per MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division team.

ii. Future (F) Player

Each MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division team is permitted to have a maximum of ten (10) registered Future Players. Future Players are permitted to participate in outside competition within their MLS NEXT Club (e.g. MLS NEXT Academy Division). Future Players can play up to seven (7) MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division matches during the Regular Season and MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Events do not count toward this total.

Future Players are eligible for all MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Events, dependent on all regulations outlined in the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Rules & Regulations.

iii. Guest (G) Player

Each MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division team is permitted to roster a maximum of four (4) Guest Players on its roster at one time. Guest Players are permitted to participate in four (4) Regular Season matches per MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division season.

Regular Season Guest Players must come from outside of the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division, they cannot be registered with a different MLS NEXT Club.

iv. Late Developer (L)

Each MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Club is permitted to register three (3) Late Developers per age group. Late Developers are only permitted to be Primary Players and must complete the Late Developer process and receive approval from MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Staff.

g. Roster Adds

i. Primary Player Adds

Primary Adds are Primary Players added after the close of the initial registration period. Each Club has an average, across the club, of six (6) Primary Adds per team to be allocated by the Club.

If a player signs a professional contract with a team within the club or another club in MLS NEXT, the club will not be charged with a Primary Add to replace that player and the club will receive an extra roster spot to replace them.

ii. Future & Guest Player Adds

There is no limit to the number of Future or Guest Player Adds if compliant with Roster Rules.

iii. Designation Change

Any Player Designation change during the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division season will result in a Primary Player Add and will count toward the six (6) Primary Adds.

Players can only change their Player Designation once per MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division season.

iv. Roster Freeze

Roster Freeze begins on April 16, 2027. Therefore, the last day to make any additional Player Adds is Thursday, April 15, 2027.

v. Player Movement

Players are not permitted to move back and forth between clubs more than once per season. Please refer to the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Player Movement Guidelines for additional regulations.

h. Staff Technical Standards

i. Registration Requirements

Any Club Staff members that will be working with MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division players, will be traveling to away matches and MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Events, and/or will be in the technical area during LS NEXT Homegrown Division matches are required to complete the entire registration process.

All Academy Directors must complete the entire registration process as is outlined in the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Rules & Regulations.

ii. Coaching License Requirements

MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Academy Directors must have a USSF Academy Directors Course, EFCL Certificate, or USSF/CSA A License or equivalent.

MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Head Coaches must have a B License or equivalent.

Any exceptions to the coaching license requirements outlined above must be approved by the MLS NEXT General Manager.

iii. Staff Recommendations

It is recommended that Head Coaches have additional Assistant Coaches, especially if coaching more than one team. Additionally, it is recommended that a coach shouldn't be the Head Coach for more than one team but instead should be a Head Coach for one team and an Assistant Coach for the other teams.

iv. Matchday

A maximum of five (5) coaching staff members are permitted in the technical area and must be listed on the Digital Match Roster within the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division matchday management platform. This maximum does NOT include a Qualified Medical Professional as is outlined in the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Safety & Wellbeing Policy.

There must be a minimum of two (2) registered staff members in the technical area for each MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division match.

III. COMPETITION

a. Match Timeframe

i. Matchday Roster

Each team is permitted a maximum of 18 players and must have a minimum of 14 players per matchday roster.

Players are permitted to play in only 90 minutes per day across a maximum of two (2) MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division matches.

Players are not permitted to appear in more than two (2) consecutive MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division matchdays.

ii. Match Length

The U13 age group will consist of 3x25-minute periods and 2x5-minute intermissions.

The U14 age group will consist of 2x40-minute halves and one 10-minute halftime.

The U15, U16, U17, and U19 age groups will consist of 2x45-minute halves and one 10-minute halftime.

iii. Warm-Up Periods

Teams must be provided with an appropriate warm-up area 30 minutes before kick-off.

iv. Age Group Order

It is recommended that older age groups play first to accommodate younger players playing up in older age groups.

v. Multiple Matches at Once

No more than two (2) matches are permitted to be played simultaneously between two (2) clubs.

vi. Kick Off Times

Regular season matches are not permitted to start earlier than 9:00 AM local time without approval from MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division staff.

vii. Time Between Matches

There must be a minimum of 18 hours between regular season matches if playing on consecutive days.

viii. Match Changes

MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division staff must approve of any request for schedule changes. Any requests for substantial changes in time or location received within two (2) weeks of the scheduled match may result in a fine.

b. Substitutions

The U13 age group will consist of two (2) substitution moments per period, substitutions are unrestricted, and intermissions do NOT count as a moment.

The U14 age group will consists of three (3) substitution moment per half, substitutions are unrestricted, and halftime does NOT count as a moment.

The U15 age group will consist of three (3) substitution moment per half, there is NO re-entry permitted in the half, and halftime does NOT count as a moment.

The U16, U17, and U19 age groups will consist of three (3) substitution moments per match, and halftime does NOT count as a moment. Substitutions in those moments are unlimited. However, there is NO re-entry.

There are exceptions to the above substitution provisions in accordance with the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Concussion Protocol as outlined in the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Safety & Wellbeing Policy.

c. Match Ball

The U13 age group must use a Size 4 Official MLS NEXT adidas match ball for all MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division matches.

The U14, U15, U16, U17, and U19 age groups must use a Size 5 Official MLS NEXT adidas match ball for all MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division matches.

d. Hydration

The home club must provide adequate hydration for both teams.

e. Technical Area

The home club must provide adequate seating (e.g. benches) for both teams.

f. Qualified Medical Professional

The home club must provide a Qualified Medical Professional (QMP) as is outlined in the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Safety & Wellbeing Policy for all venues.

If both teams arrive at the field and the home team does not provide a QMP, the match must not be played, and the home team will receive a forfeit and a fine as is outlined in the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Safety & Wellbeing Policy.

g. Match Video

The home club must upload match video for all matches to the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division video exchange platform by 12:00 PM EST on Tuesday following the match. If the home club fails to upload match video by the deadline, the club will be fined in accordance with the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Fine Structure.

h. Spectators

The home club must ensure that no spectator or parent is in the technical area or on the technical sideline. Each club is responsible for the behavior of its spectators. Additionally, as is outlined in the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Rules & Regulations, all spectators must sit across from their own club's bench.

IV. DISCIPLINE

Please refer to the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Disciplinary Code for additional understanding of all discipline provisions.

a. Red Cards

Red Card accumulation will follow an MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division player and staff member across all age groups and must be served in the player or staff member's primary age group.

Red Card accumulation for MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division staff is as follows:

- 1st Offense will result in a minimum two (2)-match suspension
- 2nd Offense is subject to additional discipline beyond a two (2)-match suspension.
- 3rd Offense is subject to a long-term suspension determined by PDev.

Red Cards received in a friendly match, scrimmage, or outside competition will only result in a suspension from MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division activities if deemed egregious by PDev.

b. Yellow Cards

Yellow Card accumulation will follow an MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division player and staff member across all age groups and must be served in the player or staff member's primary age group. In the event a player or staff member receives two (2) Yellow Cards in the same match, resulting in a Red Card, only the first Yellow Card will count toward Yellow Card accumulation.

Yellow Card accumulation for MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division players is as follows:

- Eight (8) Yellow Cards will result in a one (1) match suspension
- Ten (10) Yellow Cards will result in a two (2) match suspension
- Twelve (12) Yellow Cards will result in a three (3) match suspension

Yellow Card accumulation for MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division staff is as follows:

- Three (3) Yellow Cards will result in a one (1) match suspension
- Five (5) Yellow Cards will result in a two (2) match suspension
- Seven (7) Yellow Cards will result in a three (3) match suspension
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c. Fixture

When two (2) MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division clubs play against each other across multiple age groups over one weekend, then all matches between the two (2) clubs are considered part of the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Fixture.

i. Discipline Within Fixture

If a player or staff member receives a Yellow Card in two (2) different MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division matches within the same Fixture, both Yellow Cards will count toward that player or staff member's Yellow Card accumulation.

If a player or staff member receives a Red Card in the first match of the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division split Fixture, then that player or staff member is not permitted to participate in the remaining matches of that Fixture.

d. Serving Suspension

MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division players and staff members are not permitted to participate in MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division matches with any age group(s) until that individual has completed its suspension with their primary age group.

V. FACILITIES & TRAINING

a. Match Field Standards

It is the expectation that MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division clubs will provide appropriate, high-quality fields to host MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Matches.

The minimum field sizes for each age group are as follows:

- The U13 age group must utilize a minimum field size of 65x84 yards.
- The U14 age group must utilize a minimum field size of 65x100 yards.
- The U15, U16, U17, and U19 age groups must utilize a minimum field size of 70x110 yards.

Any field outside of the standards outlined above must be approved by MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Staff before the season begins.

b. Match Locations

Clubs are permitted to utilize multiple locations for MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Regular Season matches, subject to PDev approval. PDev encourages the use of neutral sites when applicable to prevent overnight stays.

c. Training Standards

i. Sessions Per Week

The U13 and U14 age groups must train a minimum of three (3) times per week.

The U15, U16, U17, and U19 age groups must train a minimum of four (4) times per week.

The content and breakdown of these training sessions is up to Club discretion.

ii. Rest Day

Individual players must be given at least one (1) day off per week.

VI. MLS ACADEMY TEAMS

a. Competition Format

The U15, U16, U18 MLS Academy Teams will be listed as one (1) age group older in the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division matchday management platform (e.g. U15 will be U16, U16 will be U17, U18 will be U19).

MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Regular Season Flex Matches will be structured as follows:

- U15 MLS Academy teams will compete in the U16 age group against U16 Non-MLS Academy teams
- U16 MLS Academy teams will compete in the U17 age group against U17 Non-MLS Academy teams
- U18 MLS Academy teams will compete in the U19 age group against U19 Non-MLS Academy teams

MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Regular Season Pro Player Pathway Matches will be structured as follows:

- U15 MLS Academy teams will compete against other U15 MLS Academy teams
- U16 MLS Academy teams will compete against other U16 MLS Academy teams
- U18 MLS Academy teams will compete against other U18 MLS Academy teams

MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Events will be structured as follows:

- U15 MLS Academy teams will compete in the U16 age group in all Events, unless otherwise noted
- U16 MLS Academy teams will compete in the U17 age group in all Events, unless otherwise noted
- U18 MLS Academy teams will compete in the U19 age group in all Events, unless otherwise noted

b. MLS NEXT Pro/Overage Player

Each U18 MLS Academy team is permitted to register up to three (3) total Overage and/or MLS NEXT Pro Players, including Late Developers (e.g. If a U18 team has two (2) Late Developers, that team can only add one (1) additional Overage Player to the roster.).

Overage Players will be considered U19/U20 age group players (2008/2007 birthyears).

The three (3) Overage Players will not count toward roster maximums and are interchangeable through the MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division season. The roster total will be 28 players plus three (3) overage players.

Primary Player Adds will be as follows: The three (3) Overage Players can be replaced throughout the season without limit (e.g. there can be a different set of three (3) Overage Players for every match throughout the season.).

c. MLS Academy True Age Player Flex Regular Season Competition

Each U15 MLS Academy team that participates in the U16 age group competition for Flex Regular Season, as is outlined above, will be permitted to designate up to three (3) true age players in the registration platform (e.g. 2011 born for the 2026-27 season).

Each U16 MLS Academy team that participates in the U17 age group competition for Flex Regular Season, as is outlined above, will be permitted to designate up to three (3) true age players in the registration platform (e.g. 2010 born for the 2026-27 season).

This regulation is only applicable to MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Regular Season Flex matches, and designated MLS NEXT Allstate Homegrown Division Events as is communicated by MLS NEXT.

Each MLS Academy team is permitted to register up to five (5) total true age and/or Late Developers per matchday, but no more than three (3) of the five (5) are permitted to be registered Late Developers (e.g. If a U16 team has two (2) Late Developers, that team can only add three (3) additional True Age Players to the roster.).

The three (3) true age players **will** count towards the 28-player roster maximum for the age group that the player is registered with.

The three (3) true age players are **interchangeable**. However, at no time can more than three (3) true age players on a given match day roster.

VII. MLS NEXT ALLSTATE HOMEGROWN DIVISION EVENTS

a. MLS NEXT Fest

The following are permitted: Twenty (20) players per roster. Three (3) Guest Players per roster. Three (3) Late Developers per roster.

b. Generation adidas Cup

The following are permitted: Twenty (20) players per roster. Three (3) Guest Players per roster.

No Late Developers are permitted and no Overage Players are permitted.

c. MLS NEXT Flex

The following are permitted: Twenty (20) players per roster. Three (3) Late Developers per roster.

No Guest Players are permitted.

d. MLS NEXT Cup

i. Playoff

The following are permitted: Twenty (20) players per roster. Three (3) Late Developers per roster.

No Guest Players are permitted.

ii. Showcase (if applicable)

The following are permitted: Twenty (20) players per roster. Three (3) Guest Players per roster. Three (3) Late Developers per roster.